GSP runway repairs support Upstate growth

By Caleb James

Greenville-Spartanburg International Airport is investing $27.7 million to rehabilitate its only runway, maintaining infrastructure that airport officials say is important as passenger, cargo and general aviation activity continues to grow across the upstate.

Runway 4/22 was last resurfaced about 17 years ago, while portions of its shoulders have not been addressed in around 30 years, according to Tiffany Cherry, communications manager for GSP. The project includes pavement resurfacing, concrete repairs, improvements to the runway shoulders and new pavement markings.

“The rehabilitation will provide GSP with a renewed runway that is expected to serve the airport for another 15 to 20 years,” Cherry said.

The runway is also part of the infrastructure supporting GSP’s broader development plans. Through its GSP360 program, the airport promotes property on its campus for potential aviation, industrial and other commercial uses, according to the program's website.

Thomas Tyra, vice president and chief marketing and communications officer for the Greenville-Spartanburg Airport District, said GSP expects passenger activity to increase about 5% per year for the next 10 years.

“To serve the needs of the region, GSP will need to have a well-maintained airfield infrastructure,” Tyra said.

David W. Smith, a project manager and airport safety inspector with the South Carolina Aeronautics Commission, said delaying runway maintenance can cause larger issues in the future.

“Delaying or not completing scheduled maintenance may create unscheduled repairs and flight cancellations or delays,” Smith said.

Smith also added that regular maintenance is a better use of financial resources than waiting until a runway requires complete reconstruction.

The rehabilitation has required temporary closures because GSP has only one runway. The airport completed a second 60-hour closure at 8 a.m. Monday, Sept. 21. During the closures, there were no aircraft operations or scheduled commercial flights, and the terminals were closed to the public, Cherry said.

GSP has selected the month of September for this major project due to it being one of the slowest months when it comes to airline travel, Tyra said. According to GSP’s project information, nightly runway closures from 11:30 p.m. to 5 a.m. will continue through Nov. 12.

Tyra pointed out that rehabilitation is not intended to attract new airlines or air service.

“Instead, this Runway Rehab is a maintenance project to ensure the airport’s infrastructure continues to be able to handle aviation business for many, many years to come,” Tyra said.

For GSP, the project maintains the runway infrastructure supporting the airport’s current operations while keeping the foundation for its larger outlook for aviation and development plans in the upstate.